even when the bar's vibrations were only one-tenth the diameter of the nucleus of an atom.

In the early 1960s, Weber was a lonely figure, the only experimental physicist in the world seeking gravitational waves. With his bitter aftertaste of laser competition, he enjoyed the loneliness. However, in the early 1970s, his impressive sensitivities and evidence that he might actually be detecting waves (which, in retrospect, I am convinced he was not) attracted dozens of other experimenters, and by the 1980s more than a hundred talented experimenters were engaged in a competition with him to make gravitational-wave astronomy a reality.

I first met Weber on a hillside opposite Mont Blanc in the French Alps, in the summer of 1963, four years after he embarked on his project to detect gravitational waves. I was a graduate student, just beginning research in relativity, and along with thirty-five other students from around the world I had come to the Alps for an intensive two-month summer school focusing solely on Einstein's general relativistic laws of gravity. Our teachers were the world's greatest relativity experts—John Wheeler, Roger Penrose, Charles Misner, Bryce DeWitt, Joseph Weber, and others—and we learned from them in lectures and private conversations, with the glistening snows of the Aguille de Midi and Mont Blanc towering high in the sky above us, belled cows grazing in brilliant green pastures around us, and the picturesque village of Les Houches several hundred meters below us, at the foot of our school's hillside.

In this glorious setting, Weber lectured about gravitational waves and his project to detect them, and I listened, fascinated. Between lectures Weber and I conversed about physics, life, and mountain climbing, and I came to regard him as a kindred soul. We were both loners; neither of us enjoyed intense competition or vigorous intellectual give-and-take. We both preferred to wrestle with a problem on our own, seeking advice and ideas occasionally from friends, but not being buffeted by others who were trying to beat us to a new insight or discovery.

Over the next decade, as research on black holes heated up and entered its golden age (Chapter 7), I began to find black-hole research distasteful—too much intensity, too much competition, too much rough-and-tumble. So I cast about for another area of research, one with more elbow room, into